

Off the Shelf



Halo

Rings of action!

Halo is often described as 'the game that sold the Xbox'. It is the name of a ring-world that orbits an alien planet. A ring-world is a huge planet-like body that is shaped like a ring, and spins like a giant Ferris-wheel. This makes Halo a flat planet, and you can fall off the edge into outer space.

The fledgling human interstellar empire is locked in battle with the Covenant—a group of alien races determined to wipe out human civilisation. You are one of a group of survivors from a devastated colony that is trying to lead the alien armada away from Earth. Your ship is attacked by Covenant



Another Banshee comes screaming down

forces and there's only one place you can run, to Halo of course. Once there, you are sent off instead on mission after dangerous mission to discover the secrets of Halo.

Be prepared for a tough fight—the AI is superlative, making the game much tougher; the scenery is superb; the game saving features are good; the load times are the fastest and smoothest ever.

The game isn't well ported for the PC though—the graphics start to stutter at anything above 1024 x 768; the lack of subtitles makes the story a little difficult to follow; the poor level designs are its biggest flaw, but all this doesn't take away from the fact that you're still having the best PC gaming experience of your life. Be prepared, if *Halo 2* makes it to PC—it could well be the perfect FPS.

Genre: Racing ■ **Developer:** Rockstar Games ■ **Publisher:** Take Two Interactive ■ **System Requirements:** 800 MHz CPU, 128 MB RAM, GeForce2/Radeon 8500, 1.4 GB hard disk space, DirectX 9.0 ■ **Price:** NA ■ **Web site:** www.midnightclub2.com
Rating: ★★★★★



Exam 70-290: Managing and Maintaining a Windows Server 2003 Environment

It's all you need

Microsoft recently presented the networking community with its latest network operating system—Windows Server 2003, and as expected, updated the Microsoft Certified Systems Engineer (MCSE) certification to reflect the company's latest technologies. MCSE and its younger cousin, Microsoft Certified System Administrator (MCSA), are certifications that helps network professionals adjudge their competence in Microsoft's networking technologies. Soon to follow up, Syngress Publishing has come out with a book meant to be a study guide for people aiming for the Exam 70-290—Managing and Maintaining a Windows Server 2003 Environment.

It has 900-odd pages and comes with

a free DVD. The 10 chapters meticulously cover all the exam's objectives—from managing user groups and disk quotas, to remote server management and disaster management. With a walk-through of previous Microsoft operating systems and their key points, the author then sketches the lines that make Windows Server 2003 different from previous servers such as Windows 2000 Server and NT. Each chapter ends with a well thought summary, a checklist of exam objectives, some practical frequently asked questions and a self-test quiz.



Though the book itself leaves no stone unturned in providing a comprehensive, informative and easy-to-grasp learning experience to the reader, the included DVD falls short of expectations. The DVD is essentially a video of an instructor flipping through the various chapters and briefing them with the aid of a PowerPoint presentation. It could have been put to better use, perhaps with quizzes, flash cards, adaptive simulations and the self-test quizzes from the book itself.

All in all, the book is self-sufficient as a study or preparation guide; though don't buy the book for the sake of the DVD.

Publisher: Syngress Publishing ■ **Author:** Dr. Thomas W. Shinder ■ **Distributor:** Shroff Publishers and Distributors Pvt Ltd ■ **Phone:** 91-22-27634290
■ **Fax:** 91-0 22-27634290 ■ **E-mail:** spd@vsnl.com ■ **Web Site:** www.syngress.com ■ **Price:** Rs 750
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